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Lead Feature

Sci-Fi

Imagination drives sci-fi; tech drives sci-fact; sometimes they intersect, sometimes they don't

Ram Mohan Rao

Zorks. Borgs and solar systems. Mother ships and Planet Zyclone and teleportation. Androids and cyborgs and robots and superhuman strength. Jetpacks and light-sabres and Snork guns and pulsar beams and Xanatron. All those "trons" and "orks." Those Science Fiction (SF) writers spared nothing—they were creative as hell, they imagined like no-one else did, they created cults. Sci-fi created a culture—a culture far removed from the goings-on on boring Earth. Those writers, some of them brash and in the limelight, some bespectacled and room-bound, were all creators of universes. They rambled.

But sometimes they told the truth. About the future.

What drove those science fiction authors to imagine weird stuff? Weird stuff apart, how did they manage to tell us tales of things to come? How does, as the popular phrase goes, "science fiction become science fact"? Why is sci-fi some kind of benchmark, as in "the truth today is stranger than science fiction"?

But these are idle questions, and the idea here is to explore stuff people said that is now fact, some stuff that will—in our limited opinions—remain in the clichéd realm of science fiction, and what debates are currently on about our future as a race. Think gizmos, universes, teleportation. But forget the Zorks. We made that up.

The Man, The Machine, The Cliché

We'd be insulting your awareness if we were to tell you that androids, cyborgs, robots, and other superhuman stuff is the most common theme in SF. (Actually, these share top spot with space travel.) It's quite simple, really—if you'll let us be analytical. Desire drives imagination, and what desire is stronger than to be stronger, mightier, faster, ...? As for space travel, the underlying motif is freedom... but we digress.

Here's Edward Ellis, in *The Steam Man of the Prairies* (1868), about a robot of a sort: "It was about ten feet in height, measuring to the top of the 'stove-pipe hat,' which was fashioned after the common order of felt coverings, with a broad brim, all painted a shiny black. The face was made of iron, painted a black color, with a pair of fearful eyes, and a tremendous grinning mouth." Note the language, note that it's stuff like this that made illustrators do all those tin-can robots, and note the lack of imagination: the excerpt screams, "Mechanical Man!"... and little else.

And now here we are: ten feet? No, EveR-2 Muse is petite. (*Digit*, February 2007... remember? Take vitamin supplements.)

Face of iron? Not quite... EveR-2 Muse has a face of real flesh. Black? No,

Illustrations: Shikrisha Patkar

